



EMMANUAL YIGINI

World champion faces Starc reality

The absence of Pat Cummins and Josh Hazlewood leaves Mitchell Starc as the **lone senior fast bowler**, placing additional pressure on Australia's back-up pacers.

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Few teams boast a legacy in global tournaments as formidable as Australia's. Heading into the 2025 ICC Champions Trophy, the reigning ODI World Cup holder arrives with a squad facing significant challenges. The absence of several key players due to injuries and retirement has forced a reshuffle, leaving Australia with a vastly different line-up from the one

that lifted the World Cup trophy in 2023.

Australia's pace attack has long been its greatest strength, spearheaded by Pat Cummins, Josh Hazlewood, and Mitchell Starc. Between them, they have won two ODI World Cups, a T20 World Cup, and a World Test Championship, and have retained the Ashes. However, two of the three — Cummins and Hazlewood — are sidelined with

injuries. Their absence leaves Starc **(above)** as the lone senior fast bowler, placing additional pressure on Australia's back-up pacers to step up in high-pressure situations. The task becomes even more daunting since Australia will play all its group-stage matches on the flat pitches of Rawalpindi and Lahore.

Australia's lack of credible spin-bowling options adds another layer of complexity. Tanveer Sangha,